

The Horeb Method

AI-Accelerated Sermon Preparation

Based on Demis Hassabis · Nobel Lecture, Dec 2024
Chukwuma Theology · 2026

This methodology applies Demis Hassabis's AI-as-intellectual-accelerant framework to sermon preparation — compressing research and structural phases so the preacher can invest concentrated time in discernment, pastoral application, and spiritual synthesis. AI handles the brute-force knowledge work; the preacher provides the irreplaceable pastoral taste.

❖ Core Principle

"Use AI to solve research, and then use the time saved to solve presence."

- AI handles: languages, commentaries, intertexts, structural options, historical context, adversarial theology.
- Preacher provides: pastoral taste, spiritual discernment, prophetic synthesis, embodied delivery.
- AI is a research assistant and sparring partner — not a ghostwriter.

❖ The Horeb Method — Four-Phase Framework

Stage	Name	Human Task	AI Task	Time
Carmel	Exegetical Spadework	Define the problem, the text, the congregation	Brute-force research: languages, commentaries, intertexts	20%
Wilderness	Theological Architecture	Prayer, silence, initial theological hunch	Adversarial argumentation: stress-test your hunch	30%
Horeb	Pastoral-Homiletic Design	Stand before the text; listen for the live edge	Structural options, rhetorical shapes, editing	30%
The Cave	Spiritual Digestion	Preacher's own spiritual integration; 'taste'	None. Turn it off.	20%

❖ Phase 1: Exegetical Spadework (Data Compression)

Goal: Map the textual and historical terrain faster than traditional library work.

Textual Archaeology

- Narrative arc analysis (e.g., Elijah's emotional trajectory from Mount Carmel triumph to Horeb collapse).
- Chiastic structure analysis (A-B-C-B'-A' pattern in Hebrew narrative).
- Hebrew word study: semantic range of *qol d'mamah daqqah* — 'still small voice' / 'sound of sheer silence'.

Historical-Geographic Context

- Political context of threats (e.g., Jezebel's message vs. Phoenician Baalism).
- Geographic symbolism: Carmel = public/spectacle; Horeb/Sinai = private/covenant.
- Significance of the destination (Horeb as 'return to origins' narrative).

Hassabis Principle: Let AI handle brute-force pattern-matching across commentaries so you can ask the deeper question — Why does the text place burnout immediately after the greatest victory?

Sample Prompts

Prompt 1: Analyze the Hebrew word for 'still small voice' in 1 Kings 19:12. Compare major scholarly translations. What are the theological implications of each?

Prompt 2: Provide a detailed historical and cultural context for Jezebel's threat in 1 Kings 19.

Prompt 3: Compare Elijah's journey to Horeb with Moses at Sinai (Exodus 33). Create a table comparing the events, focusing on God's revelation and the prophet's emotional state.

❖ Phase 2: Theological Architecture (Hypothesis Splitting)

Goal: Find the interpretive fulcrum. Picking the right question is the hardest part.

Biblical-Theological Mapping

- Trace themes across Scripture: divine silence vs. divine spectacle (Sinai → Psalms → 400 years → Nazareth/Tabor).
- Is the text primarily about burnout, or about the refashioning of prophetic vocation? Let AI argue both sides.
- Intertextual: Elijah at Horeb vs. Moses at Horeb — does Elijah's narrative rewrite or fulfill the Mosaic pattern?

The 'Still Small Voice' Problem

- In a culture of algorithmic amplification, what does God's deliberate choice of silence demand theologically?

- This is a theological anthropology question, not just a devotional one.

Hassabis Principle: AI can generate the hypothesis space. You must provide the taste and judgment to pick which thread is live for your congregation this week. AI cannot sniff out the right direction. That is your irreplaceable work.

Sample Prompts

Prompt 1: Read 1 Kings 19:1-8 through the lens of 'Sabbath as Identity Formation.' How does God's initial response to Elijah's burnout inform a theology of physical rest?

Prompt 2: Analyze Elijah's despair through the Great Controversy framework. How does his isolation reflect the psychological toll of spiritual warfare?

Prompt 3: I am preaching this passage focusing on 'burnout vs. refashioning of vocation.' Argue both sides with textual evidence.

❖ Phase 3: Pastoral-Homiletic Design

Goal: Move from insight to structure without losing the fragile insight.

Audience Diagnostics

- Who are they bringing to this text? (Burned-out caregivers, leaders after a 'Carmel season,' people addicted to spiritual intensity.)
- What false expectations does each group bring?
- What specific question would each person be asking?

Sermon Architecture — Collaborative Drafting

- Use AI as a structural engineer, not a prose writer.
- Rather than 'write the sermon,' ask: 'Propose three possible homiletical shapes. Evaluate each for rhetorical power and theological fidelity.'
- Every sermon needs one driving question that splits the theological space — one that even if the congregation disagrees, they still encounter God.

Sample Prompts

Prompt 1: I am preaching 1 Kings 19 to a congregation suffering from 'Carmel syndrome' — achievement fatigue masked as spiritual success. I want the sermon to move from spectacle to sustenance. Propose three possible structures and evaluate each.

Prompt 2: Which of these possible central questions is falsifiable? Which is moralistic? Which presupposes privilege?

❖ Phase 4: Rhetorical and Spiritual Refinement

Goal: The human judgment layer — what AI cannot do.

What AI Cannot Replicate

- Tone calibration: AI cannot hear your voice or know if your congregation needs challenge or comfort this week.
- The preacher's body: You are the medium. Physical presence, personal silence and noise, is part of the exegesis.
- The I-Thou (Buber): AI operates in I-It mode; preaching requires I-Thou. The still small voice is not information — it is address.

What to Do in This Phase

- Read the draft aloud in an empty room (the text is auditory — God's voice, wind, earthquake, silence).
- Test the central claim: Does this sermon still work if I am the one needing to hear it?
- Use AI only for compression editing: 'Where have I overwritten? Where have I explained what I should have proclaimed?'

Sample Prompts

Prompt 1: Here is my draft central claim: [insert claim]. Identify where it becomes moralistic. Suggest one image, one question, and one textual moment that would restore its theological strangeness.

❖ **Complete Prompt Chain for 1 Kings 19**

Exegesis	Provide a detailed exegesis of 1 Kings 19:1-18. Focus on the narrative function of the three theophanic phenomena (wind, earthquake, fire) in verses 11-12. Why does the text explicitly say Yahweh was not in them? How does this subvert expectations set by Exodus 19 and Elijah's own ministry at Carmel?
Theology	Place this passage in broader biblical theology of revelation. How does this moment at Horeb function as a pivot between the Deuteronomic emphasis on hearing (Deut 4:12) and the later prophetic tradition of interiority (Jeremiah 31:33)?
Homiletics	I am preaching to people exhausted by the demand to produce, perform, and prove value — even in church. I want to avoid the cliché that 'God speaks in whispers, not shouts.' The text is stranger than that. Propose a sermon structure that honors the strangeness: God does send the spectacular phenomena first, but passes by them to reach Elijah in a mode that requires Elijah to go out and stand at the cave entrance. What is the homiletical significance of Elijah having to leave the cave?

Refinement

Here is my draft central claim: [insert claim]. Identify where it becomes moralistic. Suggest one image, one question, and one textual moment that would restore its theological strangeness.